

Leave & Absence Policy

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1. Purpose and Overview

This policy explains how IronStore employees request, record, approve, and manage annual leave and other absences. It supports consistent workforce planning while ensuring compliance with applicable employment law in each country where IronStore operates.

Local statutory requirements, collective agreements, and employment contracts take precedence over this policy. Employees should contact People Operations if a local rule differs from the process described below.

2. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All IronStore employees, including permanent, fixed-term, part-time, and probationary employees.
- Employees working from IronStore offices, fulfilment sites, customer service centres, and approved remote locations.
- Line managers responsible for approving leave or managing attendance.
- Agency workers and contractors only where their contract or local agreement expressly adopts these procedures.

The policy covers:

- Annual or holiday leave.
- Public holidays and company closure days.
- Sickness absence.
- Family, parental, compassionate, and other statutory leave.
- Unpaid leave and extended absence.
- Return-to-work and absence records.

3. Policy Statement

IronStore provides leave in accordance with local law, the employee's contract, and approved company benefits. Employees are expected to take their full statutory annual leave entitlement unless local law permits a lawful carryover or other arrangement.

Leave must be requested in advance through **PeopleHub**, IronStore's HR system. Leave is not confirmed until approved by the employee's line manager, except where an absence is unexpected or legally protected.

Employees must:

- Submit accurate leave dates and absence reasons where required.
- Follow notice and documentation requirements.
- Keep their manager informed of changes.
- Avoid working for IronStore while recorded as absent or on leave, unless specifically authorised.
- Return to work on the agreed date.

Managers must apply this policy consistently and should not unreasonably delay or refuse leave requests.

4. Annual Leave

4.1 Entitlement

Annual leave entitlement is shown in the employee's PeopleHub profile and employment contract. It may vary by:

- Country of employment.
- Contractual working hours and working pattern.
- Length of service.
- Collective agreement or local benefit scheme.

Part-time employees receive a pro-rated entitlement where applicable. Public holidays are handled according to the employee's work location and local law.

The leave year runs from **1 January to 31 December**, unless a local entity has an approved alternative.

4.2 Request and Approval

Employees should submit annual leave requests through PeopleHub:

- At least **10 calendar days** before leave of one to five working days.
- At least **20 calendar days** before leave exceeding five working days.
- As early as possible for peak periods, including July–August, year-end, and major local holidays.

Managers should respond within **five working days**. Approval depends on operational coverage, customer commitments, fulfilment schedules, and previously approved leave.

Managers may propose alternative dates where several employees request the same period. Business needs must be assessed fairly and should not routinely prevent employees from taking their entitlement.

Leave may not be treated as approved solely because a request has been submitted or because a manager has not responded.

4.3 Taking and Carrying Leave

Employees should normally take leave in blocks that support adequate rest. Managers may require leave to be scheduled where necessary to meet legal minimums, following consultation with the employee and People Operations.

Unused leave:

- Expires at the end of the leave year unless carryover is permitted by local law, contract, or written approval.
- May be carried over when the employee could not take it because of protected leave, long-term sickness, or a documented business restriction.
- Must be recorded in PeopleHub using the correct carryover category.

People Operations will issue reminders during the year. Employees and managers remain jointly responsible for preventing excessive balances.

4.4 Cancelling or Changing Leave

Employees should amend or cancel approved leave in PeopleHub before the scheduled start date. Changes are subject to manager approval.

IronStore may cancel approved leave only for significant and unforeseen operational reasons. The manager must consult the employee, provide reasonable notice where possible, and reimburse or address unavoidable costs where required by local law.

5. Public Holidays and Company Closure

Public holidays are determined by the employee's official work location. Employees working across borders must confirm the applicable calendar with People Operations.

IronStore may designate limited company closure days, such as **24 December through 31 December**, for selected offices or teams. Closure arrangements will be communicated before the relevant leave year and will specify whether the days are:

- Additional paid company leave.
- Deducted from annual leave.
- Non-working days under local working-time rules.

Fulfilment, customer service, technology operations, and other continuous-service teams may follow rota arrangements instead of office closure dates.

6. Sickness Absence

Employees who cannot work because of illness or injury must notify their manager and record the absence in PeopleHub:

- Before their scheduled start time, where reasonably possible.

- By telephone or the approved team channel if they cannot access PeopleHub.
- With an expected duration and suitable contact details, without disclosing unnecessary medical information.

The manager must be informed of any significant change in the expected return date. Employees should provide a fit note, medical certificate, or other evidence when required by local law or People Operations.

Managers must not request a diagnosis. Health information must be handled confidentially and shared only with authorised People Operations, Occupational Health, or payroll personnel.

6.1 Short-Term and Extended Absence

For absences lasting more than **seven calendar days**, the employee must provide the documentation required in their country. People Operations may request an Occupational Health assessment where lawful and proportionate.

A manager should hold a brief welfare check after approximately **five working days**, then agree an appropriate contact schedule. Contact must be supportive and must not pressure the employee to return before medically fit.

For absence continuing beyond **28 calendar days**, People Operations will coordinate a formal case review covering:

- Expected timescales and relevant documentation.
- Workplace adjustments or phased return options.
- Pay, benefits, and statutory reporting.
- Any legal or occupational health requirements.

7. Family and Other Statutory Leave

IronStore provides statutory and contractual leave available in the employee's country, including:

- Maternity, pregnancy-related, adoption, and parental leave.
- Paternity or partner leave.
- Carer's or dependants' leave.
- Bereavement or compassionate leave.
- Time off for medical appointments where legally protected.
- Jury service, civic duties, military obligations, or other statutory absence.

Employees should notify their manager and People Operations as early as practicable. Some leave types require formal notice, supporting documents, or a prescribed application form.

People Operations will confirm entitlement, pay treatment, notice dates, and any required handover. Employees must not be disadvantaged for taking protected leave.

7.1 Compassionate Leave

Paid compassionate leave may be granted for the death or serious critical illness of an immediate family member, subject to local law and the employee's contract. The standard company guideline is up to **three working days**, with additional statutory or discretionary leave considered by the manager and People Operations.

Requests are handled sensitively. Evidence should be requested only where necessary.

8. Unpaid Leave and Extended Personal Absence

Unpaid leave is not an automatic entitlement unless required by law or contract. Employees may request it through PeopleHub at least **20 calendar days** in advance, stating:

- Requested dates.
- Reason, where the employee is comfortable providing it.
- Impact on work and proposed handover.
- Any planned return date.

Approval requires the line manager and People Operations. Requests exceeding **20 working days** also require approval from the relevant department director.

Before approval, People Operations will explain effects on salary, benefits, pension or social insurance, holiday accrual, and service dates. Unpaid leave must not be used to conceal sickness absence or work for a competitor.

9. Recording, Pay, and Privacy

PeopleHub is the official record for leave and absence. Payroll uses approved records for salary, statutory payments, and deductions. Employees must review their balance monthly and report errors within **10 working days**.

Managers must approve or reject requests promptly and ensure team calendars are accurate. People Operations may correct records where supporting evidence confirms an error.

Absence information is personal data. IronStore processes it only for employment administration, legal compliance, health and safety, workforce planning, and related legitimate purposes. Access is restricted by role and retained according to the **HR Records Retention Standard (HR-STD-006)**.

10. Return to Work

Following sickness absence, the employee should complete a return-to-work check-in with their manager within **three working days**. The discussion should cover:

- Fitness to resume normal duties.
- Any temporary adjustments or support.
- Outstanding work and priorities.
- Whether further People Operations involvement is needed.

A phased return may be agreed with medical or Occupational Health input. Adjustments must be documented in PeopleHub or the approved case-management record and reviewed by the agreed date.

11. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Employees:** Request leave correctly, report absence promptly, provide required evidence, and return as agreed.
- **Line managers:** Review requests fairly, maintain coverage, support absent employees, and protect confidentiality.
- **People Operations:** Interpret the policy, advise on local requirements, manage complex cases, and maintain records.
- **Payroll:** Apply approved leave, statutory payments, and relevant deductions.
- **Occupational Health:** Provide independent, confidential advice on fitness for work and adjustments.
- **Department directors:** Approve extended unpaid leave and significant operational exceptions.

Breaches may result in corrective action under the **Conduct and Performance Standard**, subject to local law and due process.

12. Related Documents and References

- **HR-STD-006:** HR Records Retention Standard.
- **HR-POL-009:** Flexible and Hybrid Working Policy.
- **HR-POL-011:** Family Leave Guide.
- **HR-GDE-004:** PeopleHub Manager Guide.
- **HR-FRM-012:** Extended Absence and Return-to-Work Plan.
- Applicable national employment law, collective agreements, and employment contracts.

13. Revision History

- **August 2026 — Version 3.0:** Clarified PeopleHub procedures, carryover rules, extended sickness reviews, and privacy controls.
- **February 2025 — Version 2.2:** Added company closure guidance and updated statutory family-leave references.
- **September 2023 — Version 2.0:** Consolidated country leave procedures into a single European framework.